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TECHNOLOGY

Britannica offers limited view of black history

By JACK WARNER
Cox News Service

Encyclopaedia Britannica has ventured into the spin-off field with its Black History CD-ROM, devoted entirely to black experience in the United States.

I wish I could say it is an unqualified success, but given Britannica's continued technological hesitancy in the electronic medium, that is too much to expect.

The $30 CD-ROM contains a long series of generally brief personal biographies, articles and an audio-video section. While this is, basically, all any electronic encyclopedia contains, it is rather meager in totality and difficult to use.

The chief problem is Britannica's insistence upon using the Web browser Netscape for its interface.

Because of that, you can search only a given article or an index of a particular section. That is unreasonably limited for an encyclopedia. To try to gloss over this, there is a feature called "Search by Date and Profession." All this does is cut black history into five segments and present for searching an index of what the organizers considered significant during each period.

Unlike the electronic Britannica itself, Black History is amply illustrated; unfortunately the illustrations are often murky and poorly reproduced.

The series of little biographies — only those of truly heroic stature, such as the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr., are given lengthy treatment — is good as far as it goes, but it is remarkably spotty.

For instance, the article on Eldridge Cleaver ends with the statement that in 1979 he was "placed on a five-year probation during which he was to occupy himself with community service." That was nearly 20 years ago; there can be no justification for an organization of Britannica's stature not to be a little more current than this.

Everyone will find some omission that dismays them; that's probably inevitable in any list like this. I profess no expertise in black music, or popular music in general, but the absence of Little Richard from this compilation (as far as I can discern; remember, you can't search the whole thing) is a disappointment.

However, the biggest disappointment comes in the audio-video section. Again, not a real surprise; multimedia is scarcely a big thing with Britannica. There are an even dozen items in this section, seven little video clips and five sound-only items, which consume about five minutes altogether.

Web has broader selection

By BILL O'BRIAN
The Washington Post

The Goods: As the Internet grows, it increasingly is fostering networks of like-minded people, whether for practical ends like commerce or for broader goals such as building political communities. An array of Web sites attempts to help African Americans on both levels — from employment opportunities to culture and literature.

The Big Picture: One place to start is EverythingBlack (www.everythingblack.com), a sort of mega-mall home page. It displays 12 broad categories — from arts and humanities to business, entertainment and travel — that offer links to hundreds of Web sites, including African-American news outlets all over the country.

There are numerous specialized sites, too. Mosaicbooks.com/The Black Literary Showcase (www.mosaicbooks.com), an affiliate of online bookstore Amazon.com, features summaries and recommendations on current black and Hispanic literature. Black Facts Online (www.blackfacts.com) is a fledgling database/search engine that aspires to be "Your Internet Resource of Black History Information." Black Urban Professionals Online (www.buppie.com) provides parenting tips, a resume databank, guidance on personal finance, and professional and social calendars. The Black Collegian Online (www.black-collegian.com) offers career advice and a state-by-state job database.

The Last Word: For children, Shelton Jewett, owner of Computers 101, a Washington computer training center, recommends the Afro-American Kids Zone (www.afroam.org/children/children.html) — with fables, games, puzzles and brain teasers.

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